
ON-LINE DEBATE RECORD KEEPING AND JUDGE INFORMATION: AN IMPRUDENT LOOK AT THE FUTURE

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Unless we are very wrong, this article will be totally obsolete within 5 years. Basically, that's a good thing. The debateresults website has certainly changed the way we thought debate would be, and although we could not have accurately charted its exact trajectory half a decade ago we do think that we could have identified the issues that would have directed its course. Our hope is that we can identify the issues that influence the morphing of the on-line information component of debate, and that 5 years from now someone will pick up this article and have a good laugh. We see three major issues: The interface of organizational structure and web reporting, the availability and politics of judge information, and possibility of on-line tabulation.

Organizational Structure, Centralization, and Efficiency

Basically, our debate world abhors rules and top-down decision-making. Our national organizations are loosely structured and wield little in the way of enforcement power. This decidedly federalist approach certainly has its advantages, and we do not wish to critique it as a system of governance.

As far as data management goes, however, centralization is the only real workable scheme. There are obvious advantages to having one location that contains all tournament results. There are obvious advantages, from a data management standpoint, of having the same site that posts all the results be the site that takes all the

entries. Most importantly, the entire system is only really workable if all the data is, quite literally, centralized into a single database.

What our activity as a community has, then, is a situation where our governance system is extremely decentralized but our data management demands require centralization. Not surprisingly, this creates some tension.

The most obvious location of disjoint is responsibility for keeping records. At present, tournament directors have a very loose mandate to report complete results to some organizational official. Originally, paper copies were all that was used and the format of the electronic data didn't matter. In addition, the only information made public was the NDT and CEDA point totals. The integration of results into a searchable database, however, makes the format of the electronic data important. The posting of all results information also requires that the data be more complete, and the fact that it is often posted within days of the completion of the tournament (as opposed to the end of the semester) requires that it be submitted in a more timely way.

Currently, the system works because there are basically only two platforms for running tournaments (TRPC and STA-XL), because I am generally willing to do a lot of extra work tracking down missing components of the data files, and because most tournament directors make a good faith effort to get the results in. However, if the number of tabulation platforms increases, the authors of future software are more commercially minded than Gary or Rich, or the "open source" ideas catch on and there are multiple programmers modifying code, the historical accident we enjoy now could quickly evaporate. Even as this monograph is typed, one very large tournament was conducted on software that is not in any way compatible with the existing debateresults structure, and we're still trying to figure out how to get the results into the database. (Historical footnote: By the time this monograph was edited, the results had been entered by hand, something I never, ever, want to do again.)

There are two changes to organizational structure that could vastly facilitate the data collection process and protect the project

into the future. First, while responsibility for reporting tournament results must remain with the tournament director, NDT and CEDA membership could be centralized to a single account in the debateresults website. Responsibility for managing the account, and hence being eligible to receive CEDA or NDT points, would reside with the directors of individual schools. If the central account on debateresults were the platform for CEDA and NDT membership, directors could electronically indicate the eligibility status of students, receive invoices and status updates on organizational membership, and report enrollment status. A happy side effect of this would be a central and accurate email list of all CEDA and NDT members that any organizational official could easily access; it could also be used by tournament hosts. For directors, it would be one-stop shopping to update their contact information. Importantly, it is not necessary that CEDA, NDT, and AFA change their own structure in any way, only that they identify a central web location for all memberships, and hence all data entry, to be managed.

From a data management point of view, this would place responsibility for accurately reporting student names and eligibility status on the program directors rather than tournament hosts. This would do much to alleviate duplicate records, especially for judges. An accurate list of who is debating for who, and which judges are affiliated where, would be *the single most significant* improvement in record keeping that could be made at this juncture. What would be necessary is for NDT and CEDA to craft rules for account maintenance, such as when to identify a judge as affiliated with your school, what eligibility information to report (for example, enrollment and transfer status) and how to report eligibility information (for example, specifying whether a scanned copy of enrollment records submitted electronically was sufficient, and if so the required resolution of such a document).

Second, a joint technology committee for NDT and CEDA could draft a document that would specify data structures for any version of software that would be used to report tournament results. Data can be stored a number of ways, from very ubiquitous

but cumbersome text files to very sophisticated but proprietary databases. A significant problem for the debateresults site at present is that data is converted numerous times before it is matched up and stored in the central on-line database. For TRPC users, data is entered into a database, converted to text files that are downloaded, modified by the tournament director, converted back to text files in a different format, matched back up to records in the database, and then uploaded. Similar or additional steps are required for STA-XL. All these conversions add layers of complexity that make maintaining the integrity of the data difficult.

An ideal situation would be a specified data structure, so that any tabulation programmer could write their own procedures to put the data in a format that could be uploaded back into the central database. This would also clarify what information should be maintained in the central database.

Such rules would also guarantee some forward-compatibility of the next generations of different software. Here's something scary: Had TRPC been written in DOS in 1997 (very possible, since Windows 95 was only 2 years old) it would be virtually impossible to find a computer that would run it as of this writing, in 2007. We all got lucky that Rich wrote the thing on a Mac originally and by the time he converted it to the PC windows was the standard. But the data format used in Visual Basic 6, the programming language for the current version of TRPC, is not supported by any of the new .net applications launched in 2002. And a data format Visual Basic 6 specifically did not support (newer versions of Microsoft Access) is now the standard in all the new .net application. And if Microsoft treats Visual Basic 6 the way they treated DOS, ten years from now it will be impossible to find a computer that can run the current version of TRPC.

The bottom line is that Microsoft can't really make up its mind about data formats, and that means that debate people who program tournament software will constantly be scrambling to put their data into new formats, and each new format has its own preferred data structure (for example, a preference for a table

rather than an array, or a relational database rather than XML table structures).

If the various software vendors (or, more practically, the Microsoft monopoly) make changes to what they support, and do so at different times, the number of different data structures will proliferate and each change in the tabulation software will require attendant programming alterations in the on-line software, and vice versa. If there is an agreed-upon data structure in place, as the different programs get altered they can continue to put the data into the standard format and no additional synchronization will be necessary.

It may be of some comfort to know that there is a version of TRPC that will run on the new .net platform in the works, but this too highlights the need for some direction. Decisions for the structure of that program are being made at present without much direction about what will be compatible with other software; having some technical document to turn to would be enormously helpful.

The Politics of Judge Information and Its Accessibility

The politics of judging is a heated part of competitive debate. Few would deny the importance of judge placement given the emphasis on mutually preferred judging systems, now in place at almost every major tournament. Debate coaches and teams invest hours in preference sheets to select the judges they feel are most competent or welcoming to them or their arguments. Judge paradigms are a helpful part of the judge selection process, but teams frequently rely on past decisions, personal interactions with the judge, and word of mouth qualifications. In other words, debaters typically select judges much like they select their courses.

The college instructor evaluation has moved way past the old days of trading opinions about professors or courses. Ratemyprofessors.com (RMP.com) lets students rate their instructors on a five-point Likert-type scale in the categories like helpfulness, clarity and ease. Basically, RMP.com is a very public job performance evaluation. Given the popularity of online

tournament entry systems and judging paradigms, a similar system is certainly possible for rating debate judges. Although it is possible to produce such a system (perhaps ratemyjudge.com), we would do well to have a robust discussion about its desirability. (Second historical footnote: The first author of this paper has received three jalapenos on ratemyprofessor.com, indicating that at least three students think he's "hot.")

RMP.com will be used as a base for this discussion. "To see ourselves as students see us: Such a reversal is a never-ending source of curiosity and anxiety for the university teacher" (Sutherland, 2006). To see ourselves, as judges, as debaters see us is a fascinating prospect. A system, such as ratemyjudge.com, would have consequences, some good, some bad, and some we anticipate would be just plain ugly. At any rate, expected participation would be high. Two million students rate their professors now (Wentworth, 2006).

Debateresults or planetdebate could add a simple five-point Likert-type scale to each judge paradigm that accepts ranking from anyone. Some possible points of evaluation might be whether the listed paradigm is accurate, the judge's disposition toward arguments such as topicality, theory, counter-plans, or critiques, or helpfulness of the post-round discussion. Additionally, RMP.com provides students with a chance to blog comments, which are subject to evaluation by the site before they are officially posted. Debateresults could no doubt offer a similar section.

There are some advantages of such a rating system. First, instructors can and do report using RMP.com to improve the quality of their instruction. Feedback is a constant part of the university level process. Instructors receive student evaluations every semester that operate on the same type of scale as RMP.com. Feedback can result in improved teaching and is a helpful way to evaluate your progress as an instructor. In a similar way, judges could use feedback to develop into better critics.

Second, published judging paradigms are not always the most useful source of accurate information. It is difficult for anyone to take objective stock of their own biases or perceptions, and debate

judges are no different from the rest of the population in this regard. Based on debateresults records, it is clear some judges have clearly defined affirmative or negative biases, and that other judges continually give speaker points well below established community norms. We know of no judge philosophy, however, that reads “I habitually vote negative” or “I’ll tank your points.” Finally, some judges do not write paradigms at all. Only the NDT and CEDA require judges to submit paradigms, and the result is that at a majority of tournaments there will be judges that debate teams and coaches do not know personally and cannot collect any information on. Although incomplete and probably biased, motivated debaters might provide written comments on a judge’s predilections in those cases where the judge has not taken the time to write out the preferences for them. Often, the best information is still based on word of mouth and direct experience.

Advantages aside, how desirable is the information the community would receive from such a rating system? There would be some disadvantages to a rating system. First, RPM.com has some problems in terms of statistical validity. Some professors receive very few ratings, which is likely to be true of some judges. Certainly, one ranking does not reflect the broader consensus about a judge, just as one SRI would not reflect the skills of a professor. Another problem is there is little way to know who is actually posting. If posting is anonymous, judges could post about themselves, as could parents, friends, enemies, or unrelated hackers. If posting is not anonymous, disgruntled debaters would have little incentive to be candid if there was any chance that the judge would hear them again. Second, judges would need to become thick-skinned. Comments on RMP.com can be brutally honest and sometimes just brutal. For example, one student posted, “The best thing about this class is leaving” (Skeehan, 2006) and another wrote, “teaches well, invites questions and then insults you for 20 minutes” (Sutherland, 2006). It is definitely possible that after a heated loss debaters may have some very unfriendly comments for their critics, and the comments could get down right ugly.

A related question is whether judges would be discouraged from continued participation in the activity, or whether they would adopt the words of Erik Cartman, the loveable South Park character, and simply declare “Screw you guys, I’m going home.” What may start as an attempt to give debaters more information about their judge may end to the detriment of the judging pool. Debaters could use the system for revenge, not honest evaluation. Ending someone’s debate career is tough on all judges, to be subject to the retribution of the debater after all is said and done might be too much for even the most thick-skinned judge. Every debater has been upset with a judge or disagreed at the end of a decision. Providing debaters with a system that encourages their anonymous angry rant may alienate critics, making judging an undesirable activity. Second, there’s an important difference between likeability and genius. The likeable critic is a joy to debate for, even for the loser, but debaters will develop greater skills debating in front of the genius. In a system of rating, the genius, who fails to express themselves in a likeable manner, may get a reputation of being a bad judge because young students who know little either couldn’t follow the decision or are just letting off steam (Sutherland, 2006). This gives debaters a dangerous power. Ignorant or spiteful debaters may run out the smartest critics, who even if they don’t leave the activity can end up underused at tournaments. Finally, the youthful critic may not ever get a chance to develop. You only get to be a good judge by messing up some decisions. On-line information may protect competitors but perhaps at the expense of developing judges.

The impact to this disadvantage is potentially enormous. If there’s one urgent issue that truly does threaten the future of the activity, it is the lack of good coaches, almost all of whom start out as judges. As an activity, we need to be doing all we can to recruit and retain our best and brightest, and if our judge rating system drives more of the mid-range judges out of the activity our numbers overall can not help but shrink.

The hypothetical ratemyjudge.com is basically a battle between the desires of the student and the development of judges.

Is debate better off when teams are happy with their judges or when judges are developing into better judges without fear of retribution for their mistakes? This is a tough question, but in the end we believe that debate is probably better off with a rating system for judges. Given the high cost of a college education, students should be able to make an informed choice about who they want to educate them and who they would like to avoid (Elledge, 2006). If students want judges that only enjoy politics debates or never vote on topicality, then that's their choice; it is, after all, their debate career.

All judges are in the process of development and will make mistakes, but why shouldn't they be held minimally accountable for those mistakes? Judges dish out painful commentary to debaters and it seems only fair that they survive a dose of their own medicine. Judges that are painfully honest could probably expect that a judge rating system would apply the same brutal honesty to them. Judges who are more personable would probably receive similar treatment in their own rankings. Regardless of the judge demeanor, there's no reason any judge should expect that their decision-making process ends at the conclusion of the debate. Debate decisions live long past their moment of fruition.

Finally, a rating system is an opportunity to receive feedback that can be positively applied to judge development. We, debate judges, are missing out on the SRI's that other professors receive at the end of every semester. There is no system by which we can isolate our faults and improve particular areas of our teaching. Ratemyjudge.com is a step in the right direction. Without feedback, judges will repetitively make the same mistakes. With feedback, judges can work on their demeanor, helpfulness, or their ability to understand particular arguments. Before we worry too much about the feelings of our judges, it is important to remind those unfamiliar with the site, RMP.com does filter the comments of students to prevent inappropriate remarks. Debateresults or planetdebate are sites ran by members of the community and have the same ability to filter the profane or callous remarks of vengeful debaters out of the system.

A centralized database of judges makes possible a unified ranking system where judges get feedback from debaters, even as judges give feedback to debaters. So long as our activity remains committed to mutual judge preference, there is little reason not to give those rating judges the most complete information possible. If nothing else, teams not fully socially integrated into the community will have access to some of the insider knowledge that those on the inside have. In the end, combining accurate judge preference information with a more forgiving mutual preference scheme that gets more mid-range judges into important rounds may best serve all involved.

Wither On-line Tabulation?

Imagine a tournament run this way: All judges have computers or access to computers. Instead of filling out a paper ballot, they log into the system and enter their ballot on-line and double-check it themselves. The tab room then gets a real-time update of which ballots are missing, and as soon as the last ballot is typed in by the last judge an on-line tabulation program could pair the next round and post the pairings to an electronic website.

Obviously, this would speed things up. No more waiting for pairings to be printed or distributed; no more running of ballots between distant buildings. No need to save old copies of the pairings because they can all be downloaded. Results sheets could be distributed instantaneously. Tournaments are free from the danger of printer collapse or the failure to buy an extra toner cartridge. Tournament directors can post announcements on-line and distribute tournament information more efficiently since participants are checking the websites regularly waiting for the pairings.

One interesting possibility that is made possible with electronic data entry is that judges could type in case list information while entering their ballot, and also type in a quick reason for decision that could become part of the permanent results record. Teams filling out mutual preference forms would be able to

access not just a judge's voting record, but also get a glimpse of their reasoning.

There are barriers to running a tournament in this on-line fashion. First, it requires a reliable network that everyone has access to. This has been difficult to attain, and not all campuses can provide guest access. Second, it requires that most participants have access to computers. Third, it requires that the tab room have an exceptionally reliable connection, since the inability of the tab room to access the web would halt the tournament entirely. Since programs run over the web typically run slower than those on local computers, it would require some fairly sophisticated programming to get the data processed swiftly. And, of course, it would require an entirely new tabulation program. Nonetheless, it seems almost inevitable that within 20 years all tabulation will happen on the web.

In the meantime, an alternative is to code into existing programs the ability to upload and download specific files (ballot, pairing, and results files) that would essentially distribute and collect the same information but do so by running the tabulation software off-line (as it is now) while interfacing with web-based files. This is essentially the model used to collect judge preference information now. It would require some work, but tournaments run in this fashion could occur as soon as the fall of 2007.

A very interesting experiment would be to run a tournament with on-line ballot entry and pairing distribution while maintaining off-line tabulation, allowing for the immediate switch to paper backups if the network crashed. If the system saved an appreciable amount of time, future generations of software might move to an entirely web-based environment more rapidly. The more that tab rooms make use of on-line information distribution, the sooner the community can move to an entirely web-based tabulation system.

Conclusion

The presence of the web offers interesting avenues for debate tabulation and results compilation. With some foresight and minimal organizing rules, the national organizations can greatly

facilitate on-line information processing in ways that will benefit programmers, users, and the organizations themselves. These advancements present some important and difficult choices to be made about judging and what will best keep our activity growing and vibrant. Finally, advancements in the web may pave the way for a day when all tabulation is done on-line, and the current division between tabulation and results compilation can be massively streamlined. It is our hope that this short paper will stimulate progress on all these fronts.

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